

PROLOGUE

Nora



I have always been very good in a crisis. It is the thing about myself I am most ashamed of.

Other people fall apart. I get precise. I count the exits, remember the allergies, find the exact right word and say it in a voice that does not shake. You would call it a virtue. It is not. It is a switch, and the switch flips, and when it flips I am not the woman you think you are reading about.

A boy went missing at a school gate. That is where this story begins for everyone else — the bell, the empty hand, the town turning itself inside out for a child. The panic was real. I felt it. I am not pretending any of it, and you should feel sorry for me, because I was a mother whose son was gone.

But I have been precise about this story from the first sentence, and precision is not the same as honesty, and you should know that now, before the bell, before the yard, before you decide what kind of woman loses a son at three-thirty on the first day of term.

The bell goes at three-thirty.



PART ONE

THE EMPTY HAND

Two girls. Some water. Drawn in wax crayon by a child who did not yet know what water does.



1 · BELL

Nora · 3:30 pm, the first day of term



The bell goes at three-thirty, and the bell is the only honest thing in the yard.

It rings the way it has rung every school day for the eleven years since they replaced the old electric klaxon — a clean, level, two-note chime, the same note and the same length, never faster when the weather is fine, never slower in the rain. I have stood under it two hundred and seventy-three times. I know this because I counted, the summer I stopped sleeping, because counting was a thing my hands could do while the rest of me could not.

The yard takes a breath. Four hundred children stop being children and become small bodies in a current, funneling toward the lines drawn on the tarmac in fading yellow — Reception by the climbing frame, Year One under the leaky gutter, Year Two against the mural of a whale that was painted, optimistically, in 2014 and has been peeling into a different animal ever since. The staff move to their marks like stagehands. The parents lean forward on the railings.

I lean forward on the railing.

There is a particular smell to the first day of the autumn term, and I have been dreading it since July. Wet wool, even though it is twenty-three degrees and no child in their right mind would wear a jumper. New-shoe leather. The green, ponded breath of the nature garden two fences over, which in late summer ferments into something sweet and a little rotten. And under all of it, the faint plasticky warmth of a classroom in September — the new topic books, the laminate, the promise that everything this year will be clean and orderly and begin again.

I wanted him somewhere else. I want that on the record, though there is no record yet, and no one to put it on. I wanted him at the village school by my mother's, the one with fourteen pupils and a playground that is just a field, where the worst thing that could happen is a cow looking over the fence. Tom said the city was where his life was, where our life was, and that I was projecting, and he was right, and he was wrong, and I let him win because I could not say the word *why* out loud without it sounding like a different word entirely.

So here we are. St Brigid's Church of England Primary, N8, two-form entry, rated Good with Outstanding features, and the nature pond that killed my sister, which a headteacher who arrived after the fact had reflooded in 2022 — fenced and netted and padlocked behind a gate, all the proper safe-

guards, all the reeds and the little dipping platform — a *wildlife feature* he believed, as people do, could be made to disappear if you put enough reeds in front of it.

The Reception line shudders forward. I find his face the way I always find his face — not by looking for him but by looking for the gap where he should be, the negative space of a small boy. He is fourth from the front today, behind the girl with the two plaits, in front of the boy who cries every morning at the gate. Theo. My son. He is wearing the navy joggers I ironed at six a.m. and the grey top with the porridge stain on the left cuff that I missed and will hear about later, and he is holding, illegally, contraband, a piece of pink chalk he has smuggled from the writing area, gripped in his fist like a flare.

I lift my hand. He sees me. The whole of him turns toward me — he is a child who turns with his whole body, there is nothing partial about him — and he lifts his chalk hand and opens his mouth to shout something, I will never know what, because at that moment Miss Adeyemi, his teacher, leans down and says something to the line, and the line surges, and the gate is opened, and the parents come in.

I have replayed the next ninety seconds more times than I have replayed anything in my life, and that is a sentence that means something, in my life. I have replayed it at the speed of the day and at a quarter of the

speed, and I have made myself slow it further, to a crawl, to a single frame at a time, the way you would walk the footage of a small disaster looking for the second disaster inside it. Here is what I can swear to.

I came through the gate. I did not run; there is no running in the yard, it is one of the rules, and I am a person who has spent her life following the rules because the rules were the only thing standing between me and the pond. I walked to the Reception line. The plaits girl had been collected; there was a woman I half-knew — Charlotte, Charlotte Devereux, Hugo's mother, the kind of woman who collects other people's children the way other people collect stamps — bending to the boy who cries. I reached the front of the line.

Miss Adeyemi looked up. She smiled the smile of a teacher on the first day, which is a particular exhausted brightness, and she said, *Theo?* and looked past me, down the line, the way you look for a thing you were sure was there.

He wasn't there.

I knew this before she did. I knew it the way you know the house is empty when you come home, before you have put the light on, before you have called out — your body knows it first, in the skin of your arms, and then your mind spends a long, kind interval inventing reasons.

He's gone to the toilet, Miss Adeyemi said.

He's gone to the toilet, I agreed, because it was the right answer, and because for a full five seconds it was even a believable one, because he is a child who forgets he needs the toilet until the last possible instant and then has to go at once, in the middle of anything, in the middle of a line, in the middle of his own name.

Reception parents, called Mrs Bird, the teaching assistant with the lanyard and the walkie-talkie, *please collect from the line, thank you, mind the bags*.

I stood at the front of the line and I did not move. Parents brushed past me. The line shortened. The space where Theo had been, fourth from the front, behind the plaits girl, in front of the crier, closed up as the crier was led away by Charlotte Devereux's steady hand, and then there was no line at all, and there was no Theo, and Miss Adeyemi's smile went — not gradually, all at once.

He's not come out, she said.

No, I said.

We looked at each other. There is a look that passes between two adults in that minute, and I have thought about it a great deal, and the nearest I can come to it is this: it is the look of two people who have simultaneously understood that they are about to be in a story, and not the small story they were in a moment ago. Her face did the thing faces do. It ran through the options. Toilet. Another classroom. Hiding, because he hides,

he loves to hide, it is his favourite game and my least favourite. The office. With another parent by mistake. With me, by mistake, somehow, by some impossible logic, because in the first minute the mind will try *any* door before it tries the right one.

I'll check the classroom, she said.

I'll come, I said.

We went in. The corridor smelled of plim-solls and soap. The classroom door was open. Twenty little chairs at five little tables. His drawer, the one with the label I had written for him in my neatest hand, THEO R, was open and empty. The coat peg with his name had only his bookbag, slumped. The toilets were empty. The quiet room was empty. The reading corner, where he liked to sit because it had a cushion shaped like a cat, was empty.

Miss Adeyemi was speaking into her walkie-talkie by then, and her voice had the bright, level calm of a person being professional, and underneath it something else, something I could hear because I was listening for it, because I have spent my whole life listening for the thing underneath the thing: the small, high hum of a person who has begun, very quietly, to be afraid.

I went back out into the yard.

The yard was thinning. The bell had gone twelve minutes ago. Most of the parents had taken their children and gone; only a few lingered, the ones who chat, the ones who arrange the playdates, the ones who lean on

the railings because going home means going back to the flat and the flat is small and the child is easier out here in the air. I scanned them without appearing to scan them — I have a talent for this, for taking a room or a yard without moving my head, a proofreader's eye that finds the wrong letter on a crowded page. Charlotte Devereux by the gate, on her phone, Hugo on her hip. The nurse, Priya, the one who is always half-asleep, unlocking her bike against the rail. A grandmother I did not recognise, slow and square, turning away down the path toward the side entrance — there is always a grandparent at the first pick-up, the first week is full of grandparents, they come to help, they are a feature of September the way the wet-wool smell is a feature of September.

I did not look at her twice.

I want to be careful about this, because later it will matter, and because I am a person who is careful, and because I am about to be a person that no one believes is careful ever again. I did not look at the grandmother twice. She was a shape. She was going home.

Mrs Bird was at the office now, speaking quickly. The headteacher, Mr Sackville, came out in his shirtsleeves, and his face was doing the same thing Miss Adeyemi's face had done, the running through the options, and I could see the option he did not want to land

on, the way you can see a man stepping round a puddle.

We're just checking the perimeter, he said. Nine times out of ten they've wandered to the office, or they're in the library. He's a wanderer?

He hides, I said. He doesn't wander. He hides, and he's very good at hiding, and he won't answer if you call him, it's part of the game, you have to find him, you have to actually find him — and I heard my own voice go thin and fast and I made it stop, because a thin fast voice is the voice of a mother the world stops listening to, and I needed, more than I have ever needed anything, to be listened to.

We'll find him, Mr Sackville said.

We did not find him.

They checked the library, the hall, the staffroom, the kitchen, the nature garden (I could not go into the nature garden; I stood at its gate and I could not go in, and Miss Adeyemi went in for me, and came out shaking her head), the climbing frame, the bike shed, the boiler room, the cupboard under the stairs where the nativity costumes are kept. They called his name. The yard, which had been full, was empty now except for me and three staff, and our voices sounded wrong in it, too big for a yard that had gone quiet, the way a voice sounds wrong in a room where someone has just died.

It was Mrs Bird, finally, who said the word.

Should I, she said, and she held up the walkie-talkie, and she did not finish the sentence, and Mr Sackville looked at me, and he looked at her, and he looked at the empty yard, and he looked at his watch, and the watch said twenty to four, and he said, quietly, *Yes. Yes, call them.*

And I understood, standing in the empty yard of the school where my sister drowned, that they were calling the police, and that my son was gone, and that the next part of my life had begun, and that I had known it would, and had walked into it anyway, with both eyes open and a clean ironed top and a piece of pink chalk in a small fist somewhere I could not reach.

My hand, at my side, was empty.

It was the emptiest it had ever been. And the worst of it — the thing I will carry, the thing that is mine and no one else's — is that for one half-second, before the fear came, before the world folded in, something else moved in me, something that felt, horribly, like relief.

I had been waiting for this bell to ring for twenty-two years.

And now it had.

